KINGMAKER

Loyalty is a lie...

GAME DESIGN DSD 3844 B

3 - 6 PLAYER TABLETOP GAME

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GAME CONCEPT OVERVIEW

The game where no one plays for themselves

3-6 player analog social deduction and strategy card game

Players take on the role of political schemers in a royal court

Nobody plays for their own victory, each player is secretly assigned a target whose rise to power they must support

The most powerful person in any kingdom was never the king, it was the one who chose the king

Plays in 10-15 minutes

Design Goals

Create a social deduction experience where deception is intentional.

Reward subtle, strategic play over aggressive play.

Deliver a climactic, dramatic ending moment.

GAME CONCEPT OVERVIEW

Core Gameplay

Each player secretly draws an Allegiance Card naming their target

Every round an Event Card flips setting a condition for that round

Players simultaneously play Influence Cards to boost or attack other players' standings on the Crown Track

Players observe, discuss, and attempt to deduce who is secretly backing who

Players spend limited Expose Tokens to formally accuse rivals of their allegiance

After a fixed number of rounds, everyone flips their Allegiance Card simultaneously – The Final Reveal

Win Condition

Your target must finish at the top of the Crown Track AND you must not have been exposed

If both conditions are met, you score maximum points

Design Goals

Clear objective: Crown your target without being caught

Clear ending condition: Fixed rounds ending in a simultaneous dramatic reveal

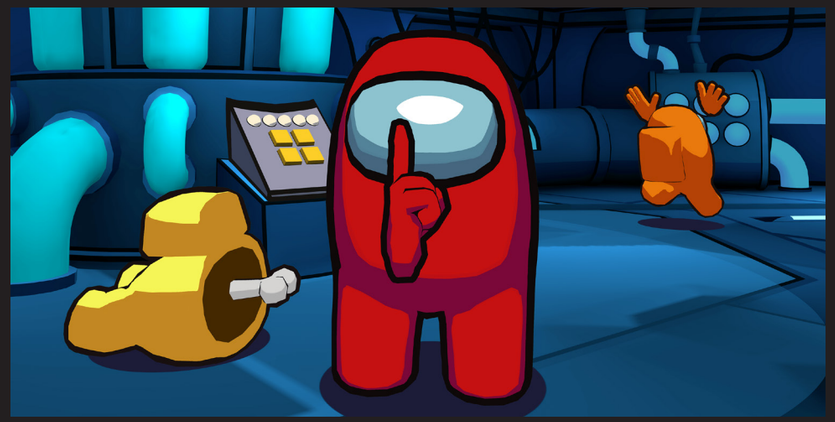
Emotional impact: The Final Reveal recontextualizes every suspicious move made throughout the game

INSPIRATIONS

Mafia

One group secretly works against the other while appearing innocent. Mafia splits players into fixed teams with a clear good vs evil structure. Kingmaker has no teams at all, every player is a lone schemer with their own private agenda. There is no “good side.” Everyone is guilty of something.

Among Us



In Among Us the Impostor knows exactly what they’re doing and actively deceives. In Kingmaker your allegiance is hidden but your actions are visible, players must watch who you keep boosting and deduce your loyalty from your choices, not from catching you in a lie. The suspicion mechanic is observational rather than accusational.

Clue

Clue has one correct answer that never changes. In Kingmaker the “answer” is different for every player at the table, everyone is trying to deduce multiple hidden allegiances simultaneously, not just one. The Final Reveal functions like every player solving Clue at the same time and comparing notes.

MECHANICS AND GAMEPLAY

The Card System

Allegiance Cards	Your secret win condition – who you're backing
Boost Cards	Raise a target's standing on the Crown Track
Attack Cards	Lower a rival's standing on the Crown Track
Misdirect Cards	Mask your true allegiance attack your own target, boost a decoy
Event Cards	Flip each round to change conditions and force players out of patterns

The Expose Token

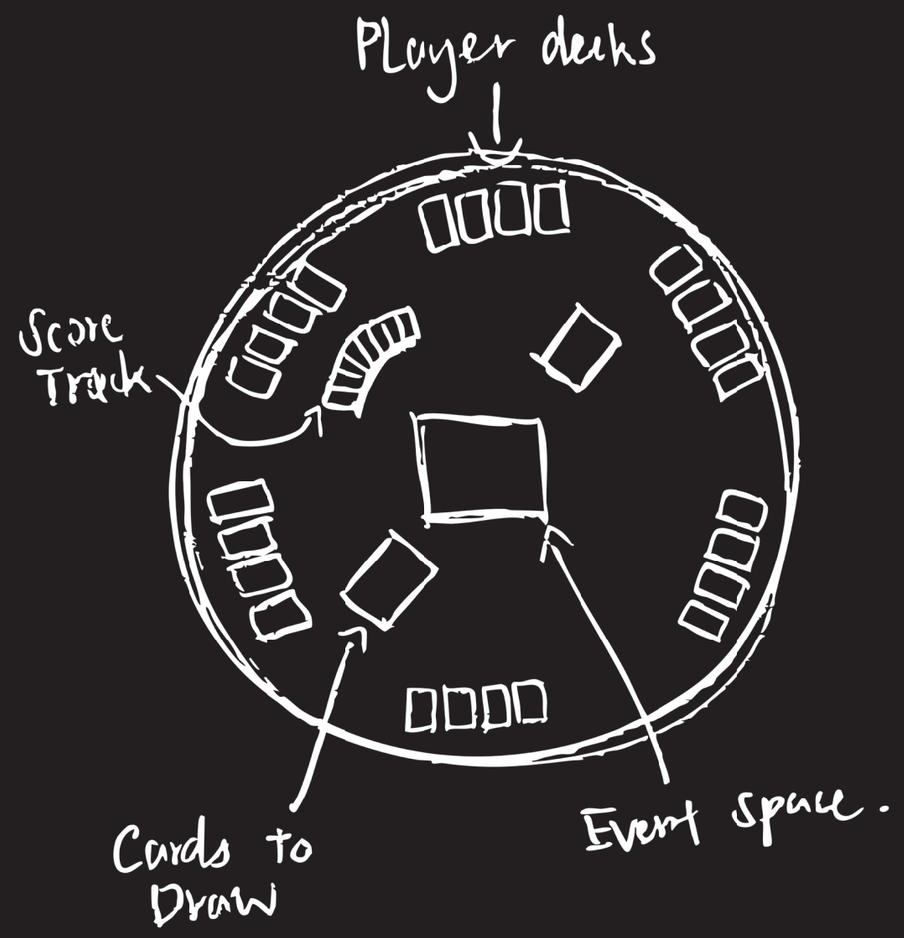
Each player has only 2 Expose Tokens for the entire game

Spending one lets you accuse a player of backing a specific target

Correct guess: accused is Burned, loses end game bonus

Wrong guess: you lose a point and waste a precious token

MECHANICS AND GAMEPLAY



The Board (3 Zones)

Crown Track (center): Visible leaderboard showing every player's standing, players will watch this all the time

Court Seats (edges): Each player's designated space showing their faction symbol, remaining Expose Tokens, and a slot for their face-down Allegiance Card

Event Space (middle): Where the current Event Card sits, changes every round and forces players to adapt

How You Should Play

Early rounds: Players play cautiously, establishing patterns

Mid game: Suspicion builds as players notice who keeps boosting who, accusations will start flying around

Late game: Expose Tokens get spent, alliances fall, Misdirect Cards will cause chaos

Final Reveal: Allegiance Cards flip simultaneously, revealing their true intentions

DEVELOPMENT PLAN

What I need

A complete deck of Influence Cards (Boost, Attack, Misdirect, Wildcard)

Allegiance Cards (one per player faction)

Event Cards (8-10 unique events)

Physical Expose Tokens

A paper prototype Crown Track board

A written ruleset playable without explanation]

(subject to change)

CHALLENGES + LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Challenge	How I Intend to Address
Balance: Some Influence Cards may be too powerful or useless	Playtest early and often cut or adjust cards that feel dominant or ignored
Clarity: Players must learn the game without us explaining it	All cards will have iconographic self-explanations with minimal explanatory words
Pacing: 10-15 minute limit is strict	Cap the round to about 1-2 minds, adjust round count if needed
Physical Expose Tokens	Physical Expose Tokens
The Expose Economy: Too many or too few tokens could break the deduction layer	Start with 2 tokens pp and adjust based on how often correct accusations happen in testing
The Reveal Falling Flat: If the Final Reveal feels anticlimactic, the whole game loses its payoff	Ensure enough information is hidden during play so the reveal recontextualizes prior actions
(subject to change)	(subject to change)

THANK YOU